

Blanche Faces
G.O.P. Doubts
Ahead of Vote

Acting Attorney General
Was Trump's Lawyer

By **GLENN THRUSH**
and **ALAN FEUER**

WASHINGTON — Senator Thom Tillis, a North Carolina Republican undecided about Todd Blanche's nomination as permanent attorney general, drew a red line last month: He would vote no if Mr. Blanche was too soft on the rioters who had ransacked the Capitol on Jan. 6.

Soon after, Mr. Tillis, a moderate on the Senate Judiciary Committee, said he had a “positive predisposition” after meeting with Mr. Blanche, despite the fact that the acting attorney general had recently signed off on a \$1.8 billion fund that could have been funneled to those who stormed Congress.

Just a single no vote from a Republican would deadlock the committee and effectively sink the confirmation of Mr. Blanche, who became the Justice Department's acting leader after Pam Bondi was fired in April. That gives Republicans on the panel rare leverage to extract concrete concessions from Mr. Blanche, 51.

Whether they will use that leverage is arguably the biggest wild card ahead of Mr. Blanche's high-stakes confirmation hearing on Wednesday.

(It is not yet clear how the death of committee member Senator Lindsey Graham, a South Carolina Republican, late Saturday will affect the timing of the hearing — or who will be chosen by leadership to replace him on the panel.)

“Blanche tries to dress it up, but at the end of the day, he's just Donald Trump's personal lawyer, and that is all he will ever be,” said Senator Chris Van Hollen, a Maryland Democrat who squared off in May against Mr. Blanche in a contentious hearing that centered on creation of the compensation fund.

Republicans are not in revolt, but they are restless. During a testy confrontation in late May, Republican senators lambasted Mr. Blanche for agreeing to create what critics have described as a “slush fund.” The deal forced them to defend a related provision shielding Mr. Trump and his family from tax investigations that might be worth more than \$100 million to the president.

Mr. Blanche quickly backtracked from the fund proposal, telling lawmakers during a June 2 hearing before the House, “We are not moving forward with the fund, period.” But Democrats have pointed to his flat refusal to put his reversal in writing as an indication that he could devise an alternative.

In private meetings, Mr. Blanche has repeatedly told senators the fund plan was “dead,” at times repeating the word three

Continued on Page A16

LINDSEY GRAHAM, 1955-2026



T.J. KIRKPATRICK FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Lindsey Graham, Republican senator of South Carolina, was first elected to Congress in 1994.



AL DRAGO/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Mr. Graham and Senator John McCain, Republican of Arizona, left, shared many international trips pressing for military intervention. Right, with President Trump at a campaign rally in 2020.



DOUG MILLS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Senator Who Went From Trump Critic to Acolyte

This article is by **Robert Jimison**, **Zachary Woolfe** and **Amelia Nierenberg**.

WASHINGTON — Lindsey Graham, a Republican senator from South Carolina and a one-time opponent turned stalwart ally of President Trump who was a forceful advocate for an interventionist U.S. foreign policy, died on Saturday evening. He was 71.

His office announced the death in a statement early Sunday. Mr. Graham had returned earlier on Saturday from a trip to Ukraine.

The Washington, D.C., medical examiner's office said on Sunday afternoon after a preliminary ex-

Foreign Interventionist
Helped to Recast the
Federal Judiciary

amination that the cause was an aortic dissection, a tear in the main artery that carries blood from the heart, caused by arteriosclerotic cardiovascular disease, a gradual weakening and hardening of the arteries.

A former Air Force lawyer who served in the Air Force Reserve while in Congress and was briefly deployed to both Iraq and Afghan-

istan as a senator, Mr. Graham was first elected to the U.S. House of Representatives in 1994, before winning his Senate seat in 2002. Last month, he fended off five challengers to win the Republican primary in his bid for a fifth term.

Mr. Trump offered his condolences on social media early Sunday, calling Mr. Graham “one of the greatest people and Senators I have ever known.”

“He was always working, and

Continued on Page A14

NEXT STEPS State law suggests that a special Republican primary will be held on Aug. 11. PAGE A14

After Quakes, Beloved Youth Baseball League Counts Its Losses

By **LUIS FERRÉ-SADURNÍ**
and **ISAYEN HERRERA**

Coaches were inundated with reports of missing children the moment the ground stopped shaking.

Dozens of children who play for Venezuela's premier youth league were hospitalized, some newly orphaned.

There was Samuel Brito, a 12-year-old baseball phenom, whose rescue from his home's rubble was captured in a dramatic video. He survived only because his parents shielded him from the collapsing walls that killed his mother and father, according to his relatives.

But many were unaccounted for, most likely trapped beneath



FABIOLA FERRERO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Miguel Moreno, a trainer with the Blue Jays youth baseball club, outside his now uninhabitable building in La Guaira, Venezuela.

collapsed homes. And a number of them — their teams still don't know exactly how many — were dead, many perishing with their families.

There was Franco Gutiérrez, a 4-year-old baseball player, found embracing his mother inside his flattened home — his father found in another room not far away, according to Miguel Moreno, who runs the baseball club Franco played on.

And there was Hiram Villarroel, 6, an aspiring pitcher who had begun playing less than a year ago, still missing somewhere in the debris of his pancaked apartment building, along with his parents.

“I feel helpless,” said Hiram's godfather, Russell Vásquez, who

Continued on Page A11

How Trump Failed to Gain
Command Over the Strait

Last Month's Framework Deal Gave Tehran
Power in an Economic Choke Point

This article is by **Edward Wong**, **Michael Crowley** and **Eric Schmitt**.

WASHINGTON — For two months, under a quiet arrangement with the U.S. Navy, commercial tankers turned off their transponders to avoid detection by Iran as they crossed the perilous Strait of Hormuz to carry oil and gas out to the world.

The military offered some air cover in case Iran attacked, as naval officers directed the vessels over the radio to hug Oman's coast, opposite Iran's shore. That enabled a steady increase in traffic through the strait from May to June, during a tentative cease-fire in the war.

But a framework deal that President Trump signed with Iran last month helped bring that effort to a fiery end because of its language giving Iran official power in the strait and its vagueness in important phrases.

Mr. Trump celebrated the agreement, reached on June 14, as the reopening of the strait. “Ships of the World, start your engines,” he wrote on social media. “Let the oil flow!”

But critics say it actually formalized a reality that Iranian officials have made clear throughout the war: They now control the strait.

Iran's missile and drone attacks on commercial ships in the strait essentially shut it down soon after the United States and Israel started the war. Then weeks after the United States and Iran entered a tentative and informal cease-fire in early April, some tankers began taking a southern

route through the strait, farther from Iran's coast.

Now, by striking last week in that area, Iran is trying to force ships to travel through its territorial waters on the strait's northern side, where Tehran can try to justify charging tolls or fees.

Iranian units attacked three ships on Tuesday along the southern route, the U.S. military said. Mr. Trump responded by ordering airstrikes in Iran. The tensions escalated in an announcement this weekend by Iran's Navy that it had fired on another vessel in the strait and was closing the waterway “until the end of U.S. interference in the region.”

U.S. Central Command said it hit about 140 Iranian military targets in response, for a total of 310 American strikes over the last week.

With Mr. Trump warning that he thinks the June agreement is “over,” global energy prices are surging again, along with fears of a return to all-out war. Before the war, a fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas passed through the strait from producers in the Middle East.

The latest crisis is an all-too-predictable result of the June agreement, former American officials and analysts say.

Facing anger over high gas prices and spiking inflation, Mr. Trump was eager to reopen the

Continued on Page A8

RETALIATION Iran reacted to U.S. strikes by hitting American military assets in the Gulf. PAGE A9

The Best Way to Fight Crime?
Prosecutors Ask the Inmates.

By **SHAILA DEWAN**

MARIN COUNTY, Calif. — Except for the portraits of Jesus, the chapel in California's oldest prison is reminiscent of a high school gymnasium, with cinder block walls and a high, narrow strip of windows. On a recent day, it was the venue for an unusual six-hour event in which the people in prison had a chance to talk to the people who put them there.

About 60 men in dusky blue work shirts — referred to as “inside people” — congregated with about 20 people in darker business attire — “outside people,” a contingent of district attorneys and their staff members.

It was the first time that Erik Nasarenko, the district attorney for Ventura County, had visited a prison in his 18 years as a prosecutor. Gripping and grinning, he worked the crowd. “What high

school did you go to?” he asked one inmate, who was from Long Beach.

“Wilson,” the man said, affably. “For one day. Then I went to juvenile hall.”

Prosecutors rarely visit prisons, and even more rarely converse at length with people doing hard time. This was the second annual such meeting convened by Brooke Jenkins, the top prosecutor in San Francisco, who said that both sides stood to gain from the experience.

Prosecutors could ask prisoners for ideas about what interventions might have prevented their younger selves from committing crimes. And prisoners could tell their stories of redemption to the very officials who might review their requests for

Continued on Page A17



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Wimbledon's Repeat Winner

After losing the first set, Jannik Sinner of Italy rallied to defeat Alexander Zverev of Germany in the men's singles final. PAGE D3.

INTERNATIONAL A4-11

A Haven for Delhi's Elite

India's government plans to close the Gymkhana Club, which the prime minister calls a relic of colonialism. PAGE A4

Experiencing Burmese Food

Much of the world is unfamiliar with the cuisine, but an exodus from Myanmar has made it more visible. PAGE A6



BUSINESS B1-5

Wealth and the World Cup

The skies above the Hamptons are packed with soccer fans on choppers headed to games, as “inequality is taking it right in the face.” PAGE B1

Where VW's Troubles Began

The German auto giant's push into China powered it for decades, but now it faces competition around the world from Chinese automakers. PAGE B1

Rare Win for a Tech Worker

A federal labor law judge determined that a software maker had illegally fired an engineer who questioned company policy changes. PAGE B1

OBITUARIES A20, B6

Part of Key Cancer Discovery

Joseph Fraumeni, a molecular epidemiology pioneer, helped to identify a disorder linked to children developing the disease. He was 93. PAGE B6

Mountain Bike Innovator

Charlie Cunningham, 77, built the first off-road bicycle with a frame that was aluminum, not steel. PAGE A20

SPORTS D1-8

Maradona's Chaotic Legacy

A multimillion-dollar battle for the soccer legend's brand is roiling investors and dividing his family. PAGE D1

NATIONAL A12-17

Surge in Immigration Arrests

The shooting death of Lorenzo Salgado Araujo occurred as enforcement has ramped up across the country. PAGE A13

Alienation in Roswell

Attendees at a U.F.O. festival felt let down by the batches of files recently declassified by the Pentagon. PAGE A12



ARTS C1-6

Teaching A.I. Louisiana French

By analyzing old nursery rhymes and folklore recordings, linguists are hoping to save vanishing languages. PAGE C1

'Little House' Gets an Update

A new TV version of the Ingalls family's story confronts the fact that their home was built on Native land. PAGE C1

OPINION A18-19

Jerrold L. Nadler PAGE A18

